FREE POP-UP CHESS CLUB KIT

The Eight-Game Teaching Ladder

For brand-new players: eight tiny games, one idea per game. Each idea joins the board only after the last one worked — by Game 8 they're playing real chess.

#	ON THE BOARD	THE ONE IDEA	HOW THE HOST TEACHES IT	DONE WHEN…
1	8 pawns vs 8 pawns. First pawn to the last rank wins the game.	**Pawns step one square (two on the first go) but capture diagonally.**	Play a bogus move once on purpose, so they get to catch you. Ask: "Which of my pawns can take yours next turn?"	they win (or survive) a pawn race and have promoted at least one pawn.
2	Add the two kings. King is attacked = you lose.	**Kings can never stand next to each other — the two thrones need a one-square gap.**	March your king adjacent to theirs once; let them say "no, you can't!" Then show how the king guards your pawns.	they win the pawn-plus-kings game — by promotion, not by accident.
3	Add both rooks (back corners).	**Rooks love open files — a column with no pawns is a rook highway.**	Open one column clear of pawns, park your rook there, and let them feel the long reach. Point at the highway metaphor.	they use an open file to win a pawn or trap a piece.
4	Add both bishops.	**Bishops are married to their color: one only ever stands on light squares, its twin on dark, forever.**	Trace a full diagonal to the board edge with your finger. Then ask: "Which of my pieces can this bishop NEVER reach?"	they trap or capture a piece with a diagonal nobody saw coming.
5	Add both knights.	**Knights hop in an L, leap over anyone, and always land on the other color.**	Let them use the knight to jump your pawn wall in one move. That leap is the "aha" — pause and enjoy it.	they fork two of your pieces with one knight (even dunking your rook counts).
6	Add both queens. Full army, no castling yet.	**The queen is the whole board's strongest piece — and the easiest one to lose. Keep her home a few moves.**	Lose your queen early on purpose, once, and say "see? Even queens get greedy." The lesson sticks better than any lecture.	they finish a full-army game without losing the queen for nothing.
7	Full chess, castling now legal.	**A king in the middle is a target; castling tucks him in behind a pawn wall — aim to do it early.**	Draw the little two-square jump with the rook remodel. Say: "first job of the game: where does my king sleep?"	they castle in a real game without needing to be reminded.
8	Real chess. Full board, full rules.	**Checkmate ends the game — not eating every piece. Careful: no legal moves but no check is a draw (stalemate).**	Show one clean mate-in-one, then one stalemate side by side. Both look like wins; only one is.	they win or draw a full first game — and stamp the last box of their Progress Passport.

Host's pacing note: one ladder game per visit is plenty. Play the day's game twice if they're hungry — repeat it rather than rush ahead. Ladder games are won by promotion, capture-all, or a quick mate-on-the-king; any ending you both agree to keep short is legal at this table.

Matching with ladder students: beginners play beginners in the ladder games; graduates of Game 8 join the main pairing grid. Both groups earn stamps — the passport doesn't care which table you sat at.